diplomatic front, including the fact that an MEA representative was now party to the deliberations. Any obfuscation on their part was immediately countered by Naveen, who would quote exactly what had transpired in various meetings (between respective Foreign and Defence Ministers) and thus gave the Chinese no room to wriggle out of their commitments. While nothing concrete came out, various principles and options for disengagement were discussed. As anticipated, the PLA wanted the disengagement to commence from the Kailash Range (Rezang La and Rechin La) where we had the maximum advantage. We countered as planned, by saying that the older issue must be resolved first, 'first-in-first-out', and the disengagement should follow the pattern of North Bank–South Bank–Kailash Range. The meeting concluded with no concrete outcome but with a clear understanding that a time-bound road map for disengagement was needed.

From time to time, the EAM would also call me for one-on-one meetings, with no aides or staff officers present. In one of the earlier visits to his office, I saw that he had put a clear plexiglass sheet vertically on his office table, as a shield between himself and visitors as a Covid precaution. I liked the idea very much and implemented it myself. In one of the meetings, he said that he was very concerned and perturbed about the 'leaks' that were taking place to the media on the outcome of the discussions. These premature leaks were in fact jeopardizing the talks and I was even more concerned about it since it affected us the most. I assured the EAM that the leaks were not emanating from our side but also pointed out that firstly, there were far too many attendees for the CSG meetings, and secondly, that despite clear orders on the carriage of mobile phones into the MO Directorate, some of the senior DGs and Secretaries were non-compliant. On another occasion, he gave me a very

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